

Tweak That Config!

 I want to buy a PC with the following configuration:-
Intel Core 2 Duo E6550 2.33 GHz; ASUS P5N-E-SLI; 2x1 GB Kingston DDR2-667 MHz; Seagate Barracuda 7200.10-320 GB SATA; XFX GeForce 8800GT Alpha Dog Ed.-512 MB; 2 LG DVD Writers; 19-inch LG CRT monitor; Logitech G-15 gaming keyboard; CABINET—I-Ball gamer with 400 watts supply and a sound system within Rs 2,000. Is the PSU included with the i-Ball Gamer, sufficient for my configuration? If not, please suggest me a PSU and a good looking cabinet of mid-range.

Utsav Biswas

 Opt for the new Penryn processors—the E8200, which at 2.66 GHz will be much better than the E6550, which I doubt is available as of now. Expect to pay around Rs 7,500 for this processor. The P5N E-SLI is a good motherboard, but why not go in for a hassle-free Intel P35 chipset? The Abit IP-35-E is a good board at just Rs 5,500 and will much more than satisfactory. I recommend the Corsair VX450 power supply for Rs 3,700. Your current 400-watt SMPS will be inadequate. For a sound system within 2,000 bucks, I suggest Artis 111R, which should cost around Rs 1,350.

Better Sound?

 I recently purchased Logitech X-540, upgrading from JBL platinum series' mere 2 speakers. Reviews everywhere say it's the best under Rs 6,000. I have an onboard Realtek ALC885/889a, as revealed by Everest Ultimate. I wish to know whether upgrading to a discrete sound card will have a huge difference on the sound, or will it be worth the money spent? I am not exactly an audiophile, but will definitely appreciate better sound. Will the Soundblaster Audigy or X-Fi edition be the right choice? Please guide me and suggest an appropriate sound card. My budget is upto Rs 5,000, but I am expecting good value for it, otherwise I would

rather stick with the onboard sound. Please suggest a value product, because I don't believe in paying a premium for negligible improvement in quality.

 For your speakers, I don't think an add-on soundcard will help at all—at the most maybe a five per cent increment in quality, which won't really be noticeable. The difference in a good soundcard is noticeable on really good sound equipment. Unfortunately those speakers don't really qualify. So stick with the integrated sound solution.

Visual Appeal

 I am looking for a monitor and I have zeroed in on the Dell SP2208WFP 22-inch. I want to use it as a standalone TV, so I would need an external TV tuner. I would like to know if there are any other monitors offering better functionalities and performance than this Dell and priced comparatively.

Gowtham Nayak

 The SP 2208 WFP is a good monitor indeed, with a good contrast ratio and good colours for a TN panel. Expect to pay around 15,000 bucks for it. As far as an external TV Tuner that offers connectivity to a monitor goes, there are hardly any options available in the market, when I last checked. You will need a PC, and take a look at LeadTek as a good brand for TV Tuners. Do remember that the Dell SP2208 WFP is a glossy panel and will reflect pretty much anything easily, so if you're watching it from a distance (as you would a TV) then the experience may not be as good as you'd expect.

Gamer In Progress

 After a year of saving, I am finally setting up my own gaming PC, the details are: Intel Core 2 Duo E6750, 2 GB DDR 2 Transcend RAM, GeForce 8600 GT based XDX graphics card, MSI P35 platinum desktop board, Samsung

SH-S203 optical drive, ordinary multimedia keyboard, Logitech MX518 mouse. Please suggest a widescreen monitor and comment on the configuration.

Bijesh Amatyia

 First of all, if you're looking for a gaming solution, concentrate harder on your card and go for an 8800GT solution instead of the slower 8600GT—you'll see thrice the performance. Personally, I prefer Sony or LG optical drives. For a monitor, I recommend the Dell SP 2208 WFP for around Rs 15,000. Lastly, a processor upgrade to an E8400 would also be quite beneficial to your gaming experience, though it's only recommended if you are willing to spend more for a relatively small performance boost.

No Dell, Please

 I want to buy a laptop for programming, graphics and multimedia. The GPU should have at least 256 MB of video memory, CPU at least 2 GHz. I need at least 160 GB of hard drive space. I would like to know, which will be better—AMD- or Intel-based? Can I use an external optical drive with the laptop? Is there any powerful, feature-rich model available in the market? Please note that I don't prefer Dell laptops. The screen size should also not be greater than 15.4 inches. My budget is around Rs 65,000.

Abhinab Gogoi

 I'm surprised you don't care for Dell—their laptops represent some of the best value for money. If you'd not have been biased I'd have immediately pointed you towards Dell's XPS 1530, which is an excellent performance laptop with a fast processor and a GeForce 8600GT 256 MB graphics solution. For an HP notebook I recommend a look at the DV6700 Thrive Edition. It has amazing looks, and has a 256 MB GeForce 8400GS, along with 3 GB of system memory. It also has a 250 GB hard drive, and a 1.83 GHz Core 2 Duo processor. ■